

The Wieskirche

One of the most famous works of rococo architecture, the Wieskirche in Steingaden, Germany, was built in 1745–54 to house a dilapidated wooden statue of the Scourged Christ that in 1738 had been seen by several locals to shed real tears. As pilgrims arrived from all over Europe to see the miraculous statue, the local abbot decided to commission a special shrine. Local artists and architects Dominikus Zimmerman (1685–1766) and his brother Johann Baptist (1680–1758), designed a confection of a building, chiefly white and gold, and filled with elaborately curving and gilded stucco and colourful paintings. The church is oval in plan, with columns in front of the walls supporting a cut-out cornice and wooden vaulting. To the east, a long, deep choir is surrounded by an upper and lower gallery. Dominikus, in charge of the project, ensured that all the elements worked together – so for instance, the building harmonizes with the surrounding landscape, and the *trompe-l'œil* ceiling paintings appear as an iridescent blue sky with flying angels, contributing to the atmosphere of exuberance.

